The Impact of Taobao's Double 11 Shopping Festival Promotion Strategies on Consumer Purchasing Behavior

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Abstract

During shopping festivals, sellers often use multiple promotion strategies to increase their product's attractiveness to consumers. Much research has investigated the relationship between these strategies and consumer purchase behavior, but few focus specifically on Taobao's Double 11 shopping festival. Based on the Stimulus-Organism-Response (SOR) model, this study identifies three promotion strategies (stimulus) used by the Taobao platform and its sellers and their resulting impact on consumers' cognitive process (organism) and purchase behavior (response). Measured by the partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM), data results conducted from 253 questionnaires validate the impacts of promotional strategies on cognitive processes: coupons and discounts on mental accounting and the reward system, livestreaming on the scarcity bias principle, and gamification on mental accounting and the scarcity bias principle. Moreover, the positive influences of cognitive processes on consumer's purchase behavior are confirmed. That is, mental accounting encourages hedonic consumption, while the scarcity bias principle and the reward system reinforce impulsive purchase. With the results of this study, the Taobao platform and sellers can improve their promotion strategies during Double 11 to enrich the product's valuableness and attractiveness, hence increasing consumer's purchase intention. Based on the targeted consumer population, various promotion strategies can be developed. For instance, if the product relies on impulsive purchases, then the scarcity bias principle would be an organism experienced by consumers. To target this, Taobao can introduce more live-streaming events to this product. However, live-streaming effectiveness can be affected by various factors such as the popularity of streamers. Hence, the platform and its sellers should weigh the costs and benefits before deciding on the utilization of promotion strategies.

Keywords: Taobao Promotion Strategies, Consumer Cognitive Process, Hedonic Consumption, Impulsive Purchases, Double 11 Shopping Festival

1. Introduction

With the development of electronic devices and internet technology, online shopping has been a convenient way for people to purchase their wants and needs. China's market involves a variety of platforms, including Taobao, its spun-off Tmall (formerly Taobao Mall), and Pinduoduo. As one of the leading platforms of e-commerce, Taobao is known for its extensive product selection, competitive prices, and innovative features. From creative product displays, interactive contents, live-streams, user reviews, and ratings, to recommendation algorithms and flash sales, it has provided a unique and helpful purchasing experience for users (Jackson, 2020). Apart from these features, shopping festivals also play an important role in boosting Taobao's purchase experience. Double 11, also known as Single's Day, is an annual shopping festival for China's consumers. According to the data from Ackroyd (2023), between November 1st to November 11th in 2023, package volume swelled to 5.26 billion, which is 23.22% higher than in 2022. On November 11th, around 639 million packages were sent to different places in China, reflecting a year-on-year growth of 15.76%, and 402 brands each had over $13.72 million in gross merchandise volume (GMV), while 38000 brands had their GMV more than doubled compared to last year (Ackroyd, 2023).

As the popularity of shopping festivals increases globally, more and more studies have focused on analyzing the marketing strategies of leading e-commerce companies such as Taobao (Zhang, 2022). For example, Guo et al. (2021) examined the influences cross-border e-commerce live-streaming can have on cross-border consumers' purchase intention by surveying those who have watched Taobao Global Shopping live streams. Others such as Wu et al. (2021) explored the effects of limited quantity and time scarcity on impulsive purchases by creating an online store on Taobao for field experiments to test their hypothesis. However, few of these studies directly investigate the most influential shopping festival, Taobao's Double 11. Therefore, this study will specifically target the promotion strategies used by Taobao during Double 11 using the SOR model and analyze their impacts on consumer purchase behavior. The main focus of this study is to explore the impacts induced on consumer's purchasing behavior classified as hedonic consumption and impulse purchase through promotion strategies used by the Taobao platform and its sellers during the Double 11 Shopping Festival. The psychological factors and responses of consumers will be an important consideration in analyzing their purchasing intentions and motivations. More effective promotion strategies are in influencing consumers' purchase intentions and the following behavior can significantly benefit the Taobao platform and sellers by increasing their GMVs during Double 11.

2. Theoretical Framework

Researchers Mehrabian and Russell (1980) proposed that environmental stimuli affect behavioral responses through primary emotional responses such as arousal, pleasure, and dominance. Stimulus (S) refers to "an external factor influencing the physical and

psychological well-being of individuals." Organism (O) is the internal processes that result from the stimulus, which usually mediates between the stimulus and the response's relationship. Lastly, the response (R) is the outcome of the stimulus and the organism. This study is primarily based on the assumption that the stimulus creates positive influences on consumer's organism, which then causes the behavioral response of purchasing.

This model identifies promotion strategies of coupons and discounts, live-streaming, and gamification as the stimulus. Accordingly, three of the cognitive process that results from the promotion strategies are the organisms. First of all, mental accounting refers to the system of cognitive operation of consumers for recording, organizing, and evaluating financial decisions and events (Thaler, 1999). In the case of coupons and discounts, the financial gain is considered as windfall gains, or unexpected profits, that have resulted from the unexpected reduction of the amount of expenditure (Ha et al., 2004). Apart from mental accounting, coupons and discounts also influence consumers' cognitive process through the scarcity bias principle. Coupons and discounts are limited-time offers that promote time scarcity, as they are only available for a particular range of time (Sowers, 2022). When facing them, our reward system is activated a lot more than the region for rationalization (Herbe, 2018). During Double 11, Taobao gives its consumers large amounts of coupons and discounts that can be used either in individual brands or across different brands. Therefore, it is established that:

H1: Usage of coupons and discounts affects consumers' cognitive process through differentiation of mental accounting.

H2: Usage of coupons and discounts attracts consumers through the scarcity bias principle with time scarcity.

H3: Usage of coupons and discounts positively triggers our brain's reward system.

Live-streaming, another promotion strategy, refers to e-commerce activities and transactions through a live-streaming platform. Live-streamers and sellers will intentionally use words such as "few" or "limited" to describe products and continuously mention the amount of remaining supply and urge consumers to make a purchase (Li & Wu, 2020). Furthermore, live-streaming can also trigger the brain's reward system, releasing dopamine and influencing our cognitive process. During Taobao's shopping festival seasons, consumers often enjoy stocking items when purchasing in live-streaming rooms due to its lower-than-usual price. When they see a daily product that has a reasonable price in the live-streaming room, dopamine will motivate consumers by creating the idea: if I don't purchase now, I will need to spend more in the future (XunKong, 2023). Thus, we can establish that:

H4: Live-streaming attracts consumers through the scarcity bias principle with quantity scarcity.

H5: Live-streaming prices triggers the release of dopamine by the reward system within consumers.

Lastly, different from conventional incentive systems of consumption, gamification is used as another promotion strategy for Taobao e-commerce. The idea of mental accounting is triggered when consumers are enabled to win "bonus money" through these games because they react and use money differently depending on its source. When Taobao's mini-games use elements such as badges, scoring boards, and rewards, feelings of urgency and scarcity is created. They become more attractive to consumers because scarcity acts upon our fear of missing out (FOMO) (Abel et al., 2016). Apart from this, dopamine, which is released when the reward system is triggered, also plays an important role in gamified elements. In response to the stimulus such as challenges or victory, dopamine motivates consumers to continue finishing tasks and achieving goals of the games. When our brain learns that this behavior can produce dopamine, we are encouraged to repeat the action repeatedly (Playmotiv, 2019). Hence, we can establish that:

H6: Gamification influences consumer's cognitive process through mental accounting.

H7: Gamification positively impacts consumer's perception of product valuableness through the scarcity bias principle.

H8: Gamification positively affects consumer through the release of dopamine by the reward system.

As consumers respond to different promotion strategies, or stimuli, their cognitive process results in different responses. With the basis of mental accounting, consumers are eager to spend windfall gains such as coupon savings on luxuries, or hedonic goods, in the "essence" of "giving themselves gifts" because coupons subsidize for the "frivolous" purchase behavior (Kivetz & Hsee, 1999). Though explanations aren't directly targeted to Taobao consumers, it is appropriate for us to infer the relationship between mental accounting and hedonic consumption based on the existence of these two factors in e-commerce activities. In contrast to mental accounting, the scarcity bias principle affects the behavior mindsets of consumers to result in impulsive purchases. Consumers act with perceived scarcity, and when they view a product as exceeding its original value and attractiveness because of scarcity, their impulsive purchase efforts may increase (Aydin, 2018). Whenever we are exposed to a rewarding stimulus, our brain responds with the release of increasing amounts of the neurotransmitter dopamine that's associated with rewards and pleasure. Stronger pleasurable experiences reinforce the signals that's sent to the prefrontal cortex and areas of memory and behavior (Guy-Evans, 2023). Hence, this could lead to impulsive purchase decisions as consumers seek instant pleasure related to the acquisition of products (Olivier, 2023). Since purchasing behavior allows consumers to fulfill their needs for pleasure and reward, we can establish that:

H9: Mental accounting positively encourages hedonic consumption.

H10: The Scarcity Bias Principle positively encourages impulsive purchases.

H11: The reward system's release of dopamine positively reinforces impulsive purchases.

3. Methodology

3.1 Data collection and sample

Using convenience sampling, this study obtained data from the internet population in China. The target population was those ages 15 to 55 living in China, as they would be the main Taobao users. In specific, those aged 15 and above would normally own individual shopping rights and have their own budgets, regardless if the money is given by parents or earned through work. Those before 55 are more likely to shop on Taobao and engage with promotion strategies such as coupons and discounts, live-streaming, and gamification. Data of this study was constructed on a 5-point Likert scale, in which 1 represented "strongly disagree" and 5 represented "strongly agree". Questionnaires were distributed through wenjuanxin (wjx.cn) and WeChat.

3.2 Measures

The questionnaire was separated into two parts. The first part was the participants' demographic information, including their age, gender, discretionary budget per month, average spending on Taobao per month during regular days or shopping festivals, and frequency of shopping on Taobao each month (DM01-DM06). The unit of budget and spending was listed in RMB since the questionnaire was distributed in China. The first three portions of the second part of the questionnaire investigate the promotion strategies used by Taobao: coupons and discounts, live-streaming, and gamification. The 3 items of coupons & discounts (CD01-CD03) were adapted from Lee & Yu (2018). The 3 items of live-streaming (LS01-LS03) were adapted from Ying (2023) and Zhang et al. (2024). The 3 items of gamification (GM01-GM03) were adapted from Shahzad et al. (2023). The next three portions of the second part investigated the participant's cognitive process during online consumption: mental accounting, applications of the scarcity bias principle, and the reward system of the brain. The 3 items of mental accounting (MA01-MA03) were adapted from Arkes et al. (1994). The 3 items of the scarcity bias principle (SBP01-SBP03) were adapted from Cao et al. (2023). The 3 items of the reward system (RS01-RS03) were adapted from Herbe (2018). Lastly, the last two portions of the second part focused on consumer purchase behavior: hedonic consumption and impulsive purchase. The 3 items of hedonic consumption (HC01-HC03) and the 3 items of impulsive purchase (IP) were all adapted from Coşkun & Marangoz (2019).

3.3 Data analysis

This study conducts the partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) as a method to evaluate the complex theoretical relationships between various variables. Since it is suitable for examining smaller sample sizes, PLS-SEM can more accurately predict and explain the outcomes of this study (Hair & Alamer, 2022). By building a PLS path model, SmartPLS, a

graphical user interface software, was used to analyze the hypotheses. It enables results in well-organized tables and provides a variety of measurement models for understanding the relationship between variables (Memon et al., 2021).

4. Result

4.1 Measurement model

The reliability and validity of the first-order constructs were measured by the SmartPLS software. First of all, the factor loadings show how well the items represent the listed constructs and the strength of their relationship. Normally, factor loadings are suggested to be greater than 0.500 and preferably, at least 0.700 (Hair, 2009). All items have loadings more than 0.700, with the exception of SBP01 and HC01's loadings greater than 0.600 only. The test also uses Cronbach's alpha (α) and composite reliability (CR) to judge the internal consistency and reliability of the constructs (Hair Jr. et al., 2021). All item's α and CR are more than 0.600. Lastly, Average Variance Extracted (AVE) was constructed to measure convergent validity. Since all of the AVEs were greater than 0.500, convergent validity was established, meaning that every construct represented at least 50% of the variance of its items (see Table 1).

Table 1: Measurement Model Evaluation for First-Order Constructs

Construct	Item	Loadings	α	CR	AVE
Coupons and Discounts			0.619	0.794	0.563
	CD01	0.704			
	CD02	0.733			
	CD03	0.810			
Live Streaming			0.811	0.89	0.73
	LS01	0.897			
	LS02	0.901			
	LS03	0.758			
Gamification			0.865	0.917	0.787
	GM01	0.704			
	GM02	0.733			
	GM03	0.81			

Table 1: Measurement Model Evaluation for First-Order Constructs

Mental Accounting			0.685	0.826	0.613
	MA01	0.737			
	MA02	0.834			
	MA03	0.775			
Scarcity Bias Principle			0.705	0.833	0.627
	SBP01	0.663			
	SBP02	0.824			
	SBP03	0.874			
Reward System			0.746	0.855	0.662
	RS01	0.797			
	RS02	0.835			
	RS03	0.810			
Hedonic Consumption			0.633	0.800	0.572
	HC01	0.690			
	HC02	0.785			
	HC03	0.788			
Impulsive Purchase			0.775	0.869	0.689
	IP01	0.796			
	IP02	0.848			
	IP03	0.846			

4.2 Structural model assessment

Path coefficients that could be used to examine the causal relationship between variables were tested by the SmartPLS using bootstrapping. After the procedure, the significance levels of the relationships between the constructs were calculated. At the 0.05 significance level, the

results revealed that the influence of coupons and discounts on mental accounting and the reward system was significant. Hence, H1 and H3 were accepted. On the contrary, the relationship the influence of coupons and discounts on scarcity bias principle wasn't proven to be significant. Therefore, H2 was not accepted. The influence of live streaming on scarcity bias principle was significant, however, the relationship of live streaming's influence on the reward system wasn't significant. Therefore, H4 was accepted and H5 wasn't. Gamification's impact on mental accounting and scarcity bias principle was also, thus H6 and H7 were both accepted. But gamification's impact on the reward system wasn't significant, so H8 wasn't accepted. Moreover, mental accounting's positive influence on hedonic consumption was significant, hence H9 was accepted. Lastly, both scarcity bias principle and the reward system's positive impact on impulsive purchase were significant. Therefore, both H10 and H11 were accepted (see Table 2).

In addition, R^2 and Q^2 values of the endogenous latent variables was also examined. The R^2 values of mental accounting, scarcity bias principle, the reward system, hedonic consumption, and impulsive purchase are 0.354, 0.447, 0.252, 0.251, and 0.398, respectively, which implies that the proportion of the variance of the dependent variable that can be explained by the independent variable. On the other hand, Q^2 values measure the predictive relevance of a model. Since all variables of the model have Q^2 values exceeding 0, the existence of predictive relevance is confirmed.

Table 2: Path Coefficients with No Mediating Effect

Paths	Path Coefficient ()	SE	T Value	P Value	Result
Coupons and Discounts -> Mental Accounting	0.261	0.062	4.195	0.000***	H1 Accepted
Coupons and Discounts -> Scarcity Bias Principle	0.066	0.057	1.163	0.245	H2 Not Accepted
Coupons and Discounts -> Reward System	0.494	0.065	7.623	0.000***	H3 Accepted
Live Streaming -> Scarcity Bias Principle	0.482	0.053	9.095	0.000***	H4 Accepted
Live Streaming -> Reward System	-0.013	0.071	0.183	0.855	H5 Not Accepted
Gamification -> Mental Accounting	0.469	0.053	8.871	0.000***	H6 Accepted

Table 2: Path Coefficients with No Mediating Effect

Gamification -> Scarcity Bias Principle	0.25	0.058	4.34	0.000***	H7 Accepted
Gamification -> Reward System	0.04	0.078	0.518	0.604	H8 Not Accepted
Mental Accounting -> Hedonic Consumption	0.501	0.048	10.492	0.000***	H9 Accepted
Scarcity Bias Principle -> Impulsive Purchases	0.578	0.039	14.703	0.000***	H10 Accepted
Reward System -> Impulsive Purchases	0.156	0.055	2.83	0.005**	H11 Accepted

**P<0.01; ***P<0.001

5. Conclusion: Discussion and Implications

The purpose of the study is to examine how Taobao increases its sales through promotion strategies during Double 11 by positively influencing consumers' cognitive processes and purchase behaviors. The SOR model used identifies promotion strategies as the stimulus, cognitive processes as the organism, and purchase behaviors as the response. Based on the SOR model and results of the data analysis, it is reasonable for us to conclude that by utilizing coupons and discounts, live-streaming, and gamification during Double 11, the Taobao platform and its sellers demonstrate positive influences of certain promotion strategies on consumer's cognitive process through mental accounting, the scarcity bias principle, and the reward system. Furthermore, the results also fully support the theoretical relationship between cognitive processes and purchase behaviors.

First, the findings of this study validate the findings of previous studies on highlighting the impact of promotion strategies on mental accounting, the scarcity bias principle, and the reward system (Ha et al., 2004; Zheng & Ma, 2021; Herbe, 2018). With the data results of both H1 and H3, we can conclude that Taobao's usage of coupons and discounts during Double 11 largely influences consumers' mental accounting and the reward system. H2, on the other hand, suggests that with time-limited offers, products are perceived as more valuable due to FOMO. A reasonable explanation for this is that although the Taobao platform and its sellers provide consumers with different types of coupons and discounts during Double 11, the available time limit often stretches to more than a week. Hence, the effect of these time-limited offers on the scarcity bias principle wouldn't be as prominent, since consumers aren't afraid of "missing out"

knowing they have time to find a new substitute. Similarly, this study agrees with previous studies of Li & Wu (2020) on the impact of live-streaming on the scarcity bias principle since H4 is accepted. On the contrary, the relationship between live-streaming and the reward system is not accepted by the results of this study. Empirically, the neurotransmitter dopamine acts as an alert system that forces us to focus on anything beneficial to us. Once it identifies a significantly cheaper price in the live-streaming room, dopamine will motivate us to purchase more, even if we have already obtained the product (XunKong, 2023). Double 11 urges consumers to watch the live streams and wait long hours before being able to purchase a product (Li, 2021). Hours of waiting and the fear of not being able to obtain a desired product may have negative impacts on the consumer's reward system. Therefore, we cannot conclude that live-streaming can have an influential positive impact on the reward system of consumers.

Moreover, gamification's influence on mental accounting (H6) and the scarcity bias principle (H7) are both accepted by this study's results. In contrast, gamification's influence on the reward system isn't accepted by the results of this study (H8). Empirical evidences show that dopamine can motivate our brain to repeat wanted behaviors. Once triggered by stimulus such as challenges or victory that's present in mini-games, our brain learns to produce this neurotransmitter in order to continue such actions (Playmotiv, 2019). However, the designs of Taobao's Double 11 mini-games may create opposite effects on consumer's cognitive process. Because of this mechanism, the mini-game received numerous backfires, with players complaining about devoting so many efforts but receiving only small amounts of money. The lack of clarity of the distribution of rewards causes negative influence on consumer's cognitive perception, hence H8 is an acceptable relationship. Finally, this study also explores the relationship between three cognitive processes and the resulting purchase behavior (H9-H11). The obtained results are also consistent with past studies of Kivetz & Hsee (1999), Aydin (2018), and Olivier (2023).

We suggest that the Taobao platform and its sellers should increase their usage of strategies based on the desired purchase behavior. If their targeted consumer focuses on hedonic consumption, they should aim to influence consumers' mental accounting to increase purchase behavior. Both coupons and discounts and gamification mechanisms would help the platform and individual sellers increase their sales. On the other hand, if the product relies on impulsive purchase, then the scarcity bias principle and the reward system would be more beneficial in boosting sales. The Taobao platform and its sellers should then weigh between the three promotion strategies to determine which is more applicable for them.

This study mainly focuses on the Chinese market of Taobao e-commerce, so the results may only be effective for sellers selling their products on Taobao's Chinese platform, instead of the global platform. To provide more accurate results, this study can improve by including a greater number of received questionnaires: the greater the population, the more precise the results will be. Furthermore, to provide a more holistic review of the impact of Taobao's

promotion strategies on consumers, future research should expand to other strategies such as Tao Coin and 88 VIP (Zhang, 2022).

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